

Giving & Receiving in Japanese

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Overview

Japanese has **three different verbs** for “to give.”

Your choice depends on **who is giving what to whom**.

The key factor is whether the gift moves:

- **Inward** — from outside your group to inside your group, or
- **Outward** — from inside your group to outside your group.

Who is “inside” and “outside” depends on **context**, not absolute relationships.

In-Group / Out-Group Examples

Situation	Direction
Your dad gives something to you	✓ Inward
You give something to your dad	✗ Outward
Your boss gives something to your dad	✓ Inward (dad is closer to you than your boss)
Someone from another company gives something to your boss	✓ Inward (your company is your in-group)
Your dad gives something to your boss	✗ Outward
Your boss gives something to another company	✗ Outward

1. くれる — Inward Giving

Use くれる when something moves **inward** (toward you or your in-group).
The **recipient** is marked by **に**.

ちち わたし ほん
父が私に本をくれました。

My father gave (inwards) a book to me.

パパ なに
父に何をくれた？

What did you (outside our family) give my dad?

しゃ ぶちょう
A社はいつ部長にレポートをくれる？

When will Company A give our Head of Department the report?

⚠ You would **never** use くれる if *you* or a co-worker gave the report to your HoD — that would be outward.

2. あげる — Outward Giving

Use あげる when something moves **outward** (from you or your in-group to someone outside).

The **recipient** is marked by **に**.

わたし ちち ほん
私は父に本をあげた。

I gave (outwards) a book to my dad.

ちち はな みず
父の花に水をあげた。

I gave (outwards) water to my dad's flowers.

おまえ いちえん
俺には一円もあげない。

I'm not giving you even one yen.

3. やる — Outward Giving (disrespectful or casual)

やる is also outward, but it carries a tone of:

- Disrespect / looking down on someone, or
- Casual giving to **non-humans** (animals, plants).

のらねこ えさ か
野良猫に餌を買ってやった。

I bought the stray cat food (casual, non-human).

おまえ おし
俺に教えてやる。

I'll teach you a lesson (you scum).

4. もらう — Receiving

もらう means “to receive” or “get.”

It does **not** care about direction.

The **giver** is marked by に or から.

The **receiver** is marked by は / が.

ちち ほん
父から本をもらった。

I got a book from my dad.

あけてもらいました。

(Someone) opened it for me.

⚠️ てもらう can sound **threatening** when directed at the doer:

せつめい
説明してもらおうよ

“You'll be explaining this to me (and you have no choice).”

5. Verb + て Form + Giving / Receiving Verbs

All three giving verbs can attach to the **て-form** of another verb to show:

- Direction of action (inward / outward),
- That the action was done as a **favor**,
- Or to express **thanks** (or lack thereof).

Japanese

Meaning

ちち つく
父に作ってくれた。

Someone outside our family made it for my dad (inward).

ちち つく
父に作ってあげた。

I (or my siblings) made it for my dad (outward).

ちち つく
父に作ってやった。

I made it for dad — but I dislike him / want to sound tough.

せつめい
説明してくれる？

Will you explain it to me/us (as a favor)?

せつめい
説明してあげた。

I/we explained it to you/them.

せつめい
説明してやるぞ。

Fine, I'll explain it to you (and I'm looking down on you).

せんせい おし
先生が教えてくれた。

The teacher taught me (as a favor).

か
みきちゃんに買ってくれた？

You bought this for Miki (who I'm close to)?

か
みきちゃんに買ってあげました。

We bought this for Miki (who is an outsider or equal).

Be careful using あげる to talk about your own actions to the recipient — it can sound **pretentious** or **haughty** ("I did this for YOU").

6. Side-by-Side Comparison

Four sentences with the same basic meaning, using each verb.

Over-translated to show the grammar clearly.

たなかさんは^{わたし}私に^{ほん}本をくれました。

*Tanaka gave (inwards) a book to **me**.*

^{わたし}私は^{ほん}たなかさんに本をあげました。

***I** gave (outwards) a book to Tanaka.*

^{わたし}私は^{ほん}たなかさんに本をもらいました。

***I** received a book from Tanaka.*

^{わたし}私は^{ほん}たなかさんに本をやりました。

***I** (disrespectfully) gave a book to Tanaka.*

Key Particle Summary

Verb	Direction	Giver Marker	Receiver Marker
くれる	Inward	は / が	に
あげる	Outward	は / が	に
やる	Outward (disrespectful)	は / が	に
もらう	Neutral (receiving)	に / から	は / が

Final Tips

- **くれる** = someone gives to **you or your in-group**.
- **あげる** = **you or your in-group** gives to someone else.

- やる = like あげる but **rude** or used for **animals / plants**.
- もらう = **you receive** — focus is on the receiver, not direction.

Based on the original document by Dr. Wes Robertson — reformatted for clarity.